

A Personal Brief

what to do with and for the piece next · 11 August 2026 · for @jeffrey only

The admin is handled and listed elsewhere. This is about whether the evening is any good, and what would make it so.

1. The one artistic question

You have billed two pieces as one evening, and the only thing currently joining them is a *hardware* contrast: rescued machines against bought ones. That is a good **poster**. It is not yet a good **concert**.

Nothing in either work currently listens to the other. *Note(s)pat(ial)* is a spatial field on six machines; *The MacNeoPolitan Trio* is a hocketed conversation between three. An audience will hear two unrelated sets and a programme note explaining that they rhyme conceptually.

The fix is cheap and it is musical. Carry one thing across the gap — a motif, an interval, a tuning, a tempo relationship, a single held pitch. Let the six salvaged machines state something, and let the three new ones answer it twenty minutes later with the same material on different hardware. Then the e-waste-versus-new argument is something the room *hears* rather than something it reads.

Concretely: the notepat cell you already know, stated plainly by the six, then returned by the trio through Menu Band — same pitches, utterly different timbre and spatial behaviour. That single decision converts the evening from a double bill into a piece.

2. The technical fork that changes the composition

RESOLVE BEFORE YOU WRITE ANYTHING

Note(s)pat(ial) assumes six **discrete** channels — one salvaged laptop per Kalio speaker, the audience inside the field. Your own rider lists this as unverified, in three separate places: whether the Kalio takes six discrete inputs or requires a house mixer, the sixth-channel bandwidth, and the exact speaker layout.

This is not a production detail. It is the difference between two compositions:

If six discrete	The piece you proposed. Each machine is a voice with a fixed location; rotation means reassigning voices between physical speakers. Compose <i>per-machine parts</i> .
If a house mixer, or fewer than six	Location becomes a pan value, not a machine. The salvage argument weakens — the audience can no longer hear that each sound is a different computer. Compose <i>a stereo-plus-spread field</i> and lean the concept onto the visible rack instead of the routing.

Ask CultureHub this week, in one message, and ask for the studio floorplan while you are at it — it is referenced on their site but not published, so it has to be requested. Until it is answered, do not write per-machine parts you may have to throw away.

3. Compose before you arrive; use the room for what only the room can do

You have ten days in residence. They are the most expensive ten days in the project, and they are the *only* time you have the Kalio system.

Do not spend them writing notes. Spend them on the things that cannot be done anywhere else: spatial realisation, rotation gestures, channel tests, how the field behaves with bodies in the room, and rehearsal against the actual PA.

That means arriving on 16 September with: parts written, a running order fixed, both pieces playable end-to-end on your own hardware, and a documented failure plan. The residency is for *staging*, not authorship. This is the single biggest determinant of whether the 24 September performance is good.

4. Note(s)pat(ial) — from 1:41 fixed to twenty minutes live

The honest gap: you have a fixed 1:41 recording of a spatial composition, and you have promised a live, variable, twenty-minute version. That is a twelvefold expansion and a change of medium — from a rendered object to an instrument you play.

What that actually requires, in order:

- a A control surface you can actually play.** Rotation, speed, trajectory, and voice-redistribution need to be under your hands in real time. Right now this is described but not built. It is the riskiest unbuilt thing in the programme. Build it first and play it for weeks.
- b A form that survives twenty minutes.** 1:41 of material stretched twelvefold becomes wallpaper unless it has sections. Give it a shape you can steer — a slow reveal of the field, a densification, a redistribution event, a collapse to one machine, a return.
- c Per-machine parts** (pending \$2). Six voices that are individually boring and collectively alive.
- d A one-machine-down version.** Six salvaged laptops means one will fail. Decide now whether the piece survives on five, and how you drop a voice gracefully mid-performance.

5. The MacNeoPolitan Trio — score the behaviours the format already has

This piece is further from existing than piece one, but it is much better defined, because the `.mbscore` format already encodes its three ideas: **hocket** (one melody split note-by-note across machines), **circle trade** (call-and-response, non-soloists holding the bass root), and **one downbeat** (three machines, no cable, one NTP-locked pulse).

You do not need to invent this piece. You need to write three movements, one per behaviour, and let the third one be the argument: three separate computers with no wire between them, agreeing on a downbeat. That is the whole thesis of the work, and it is audible without explanation.

Two constraints to respect. The blush machine does not exist yet, so score for three but rehearse the two-machine reduction as a real fallback. And Menu Band is a shipping macOS app, not AC Native — never let copy or speech blur that, including on stage.

6. Make the guest a hinge, not a gap

Right now the guest set exists because the changeover between the salvaged rack and the three Neos is a hardware swap that needs covering. That is a stagehand's reason, and the audience will feel it.

Invite someone whose set can *be* the transition — ideally someone who plays into or across both systems, or who performs on one of your machines. Then the ten minutes are dramaturgy instead of dead air, and the evening has three movements rather than two sets plus an interruption.

Whoever it is, ask them this week. The fee comes out of your \$2,000, the rider changes, and CultureHub publishes the credit — all of which want lead time.

7. Rehearse the failures, not the pieces

Nine computers, two operating systems, NTP-synced clocks, no LAN, six discrete channels, and a hardware swap in the middle of a public performance. The pieces will be fine. The evening breaks at the seams.

Drill these specifically: a laptop that will not boot at load-in · clock drift across the trio mid-piece · one Kalio channel dead · the changeover under time pressure with an audience watching · neo's memory pressure during the trio (decide the clean-boot question, or stand a fourth machine by) · and a total audio failure with a room full of people.

8. Working back from 16 September

Window	The work
This week	Resolve the Kalio question and request the floorplan. Ask the guest. Decide the shared musical material from \$1.
Aug 18–31	Build the live control surface and play it daily. Buy the blush Neo. Write the three trio movements against the <code>.mbscore</code> behaviours.
Sept 1–10	Write <i>Note(s)pat(ial)</i> 's per-machine parts and its twenty-minute form. Source and image all six salvaged machines.
Sept 11–15	Full run at home on all nine machines. Drill the failure list. Freeze the running order.
Sept 16–25	Spatial realisation, rotation rehearsal, channel tests, the jam, the performance. <i>No composing</i> .

9. If you only do one thing

Decide the material that crosses between the two pieces, and write it down this week. Everything else on every list is logistics. That decision is the difference between a residency that produced two demos and one that produced a work you will tour.

